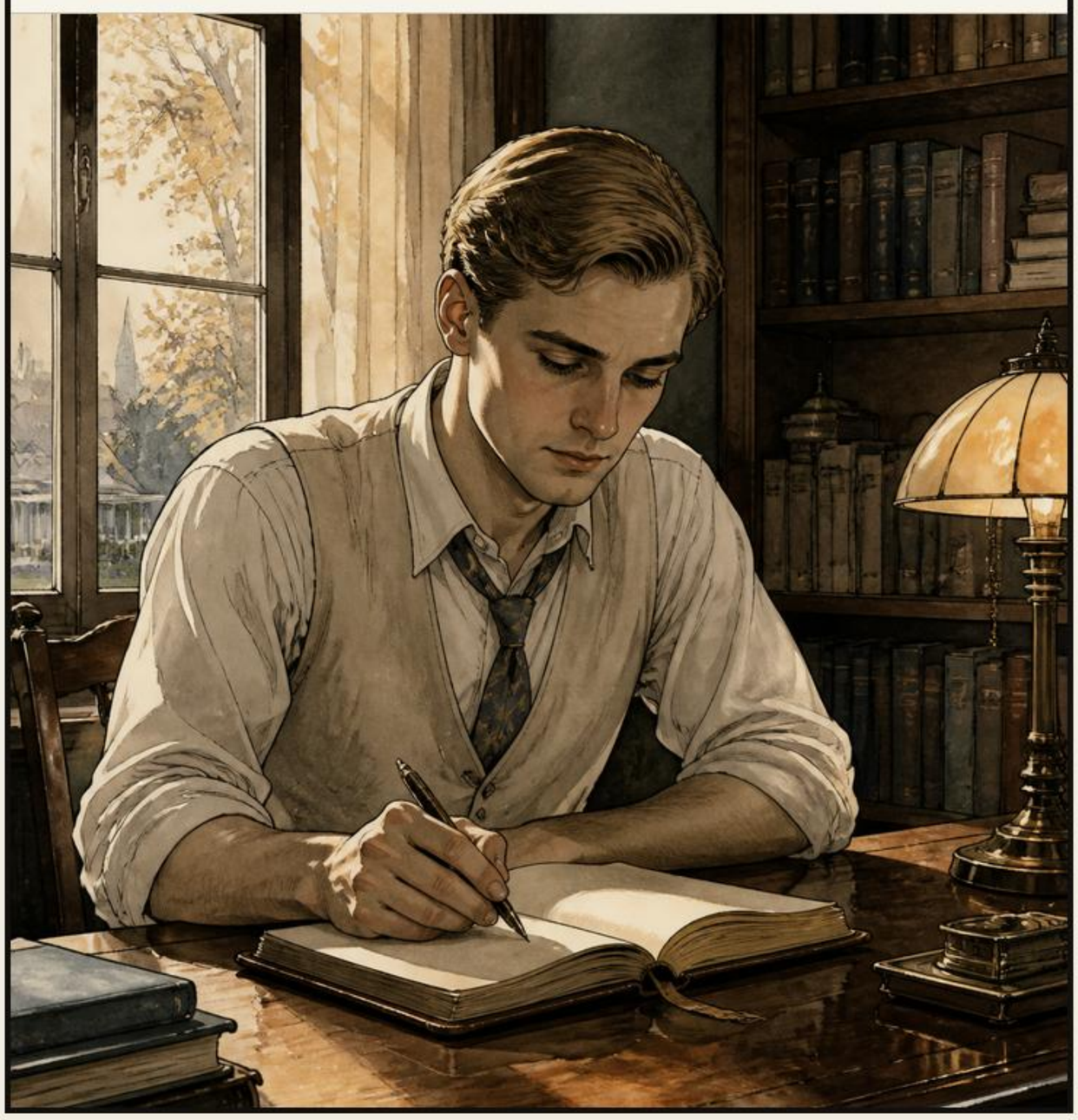
In my younger and more vulnerable years, my father gave me some advice I've been turning over ever since.

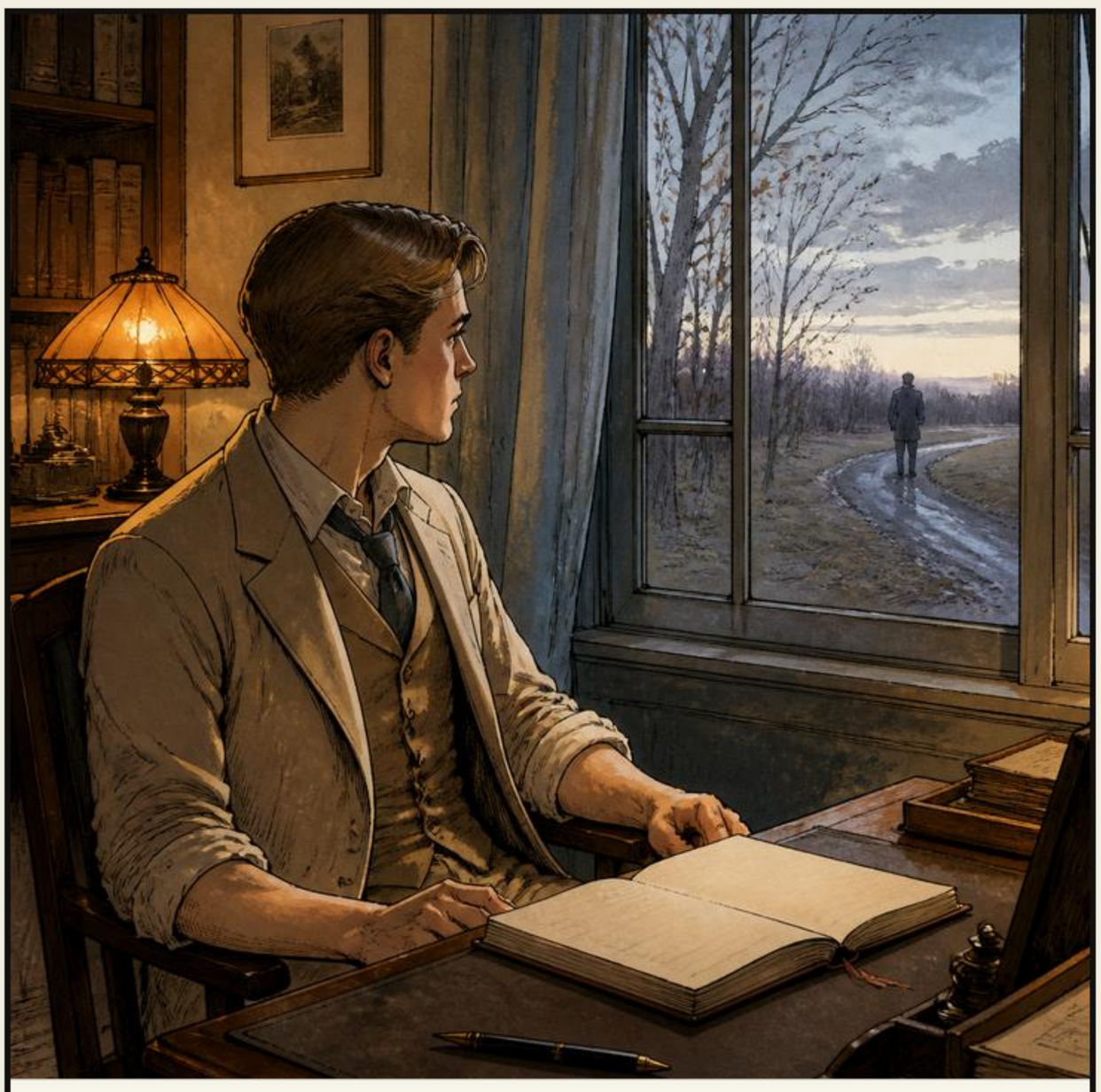


My father told me to remember that not everyone had my advantages. He didn't say more, but we'd always been communicative in a reserved way. I understood he meant a great deal more than that.



Reserving judgement opened curious natures to me. In college I was unjustly accused of being a politician, because I was privy to the secret griefs of wild, unknown men—confidences I never sought.





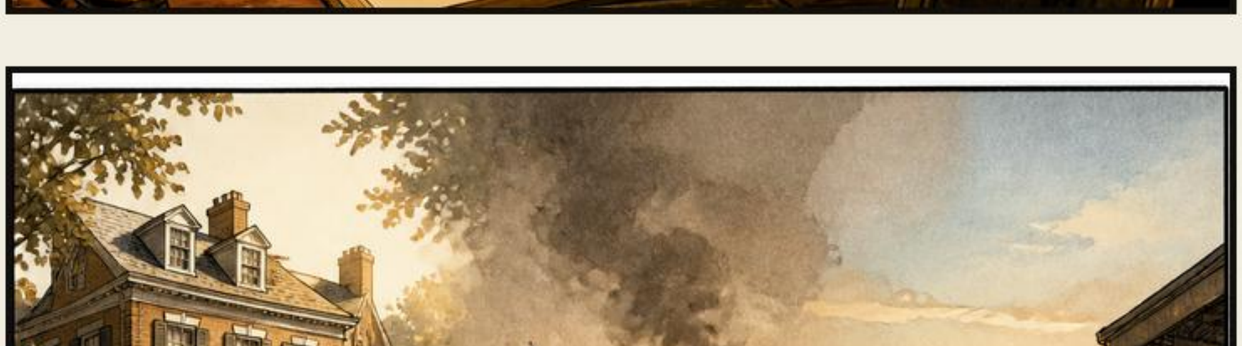
Reserving judgement is a matter of infinite hope—yet, after boasting of my tolerance, I admit it has a limit. When I came back from the East last autumn, I wanted the world in uniform and at moral attention forever.

Only Gatsby was exempt from my reaction — Gatsby, who represented everything for which I have an unaffected scorn. And yet there was something gorgeous about him, a sensitivity to the promises of life, as though he were tuned to earthquakes ten thousand miles away.



It was an extraordinary gift for hope, a romantic readiness I shall not find again. No — Gatsby turned out all right at the end; it was the foul dust that floated in the wake of his dreams that closed out my interest in the sorrows of men.





The Middle West now seemed the ragged edge of the universe — so I decided to go East and learn the bond business. Father agreed to finance me for a year, and in the spring of twenty-two I came East, permanently, I thought. The practical thing was rooms in the city; but when a young man at the office suggested we take a house together in a commuting town, it sounded like a great idea.

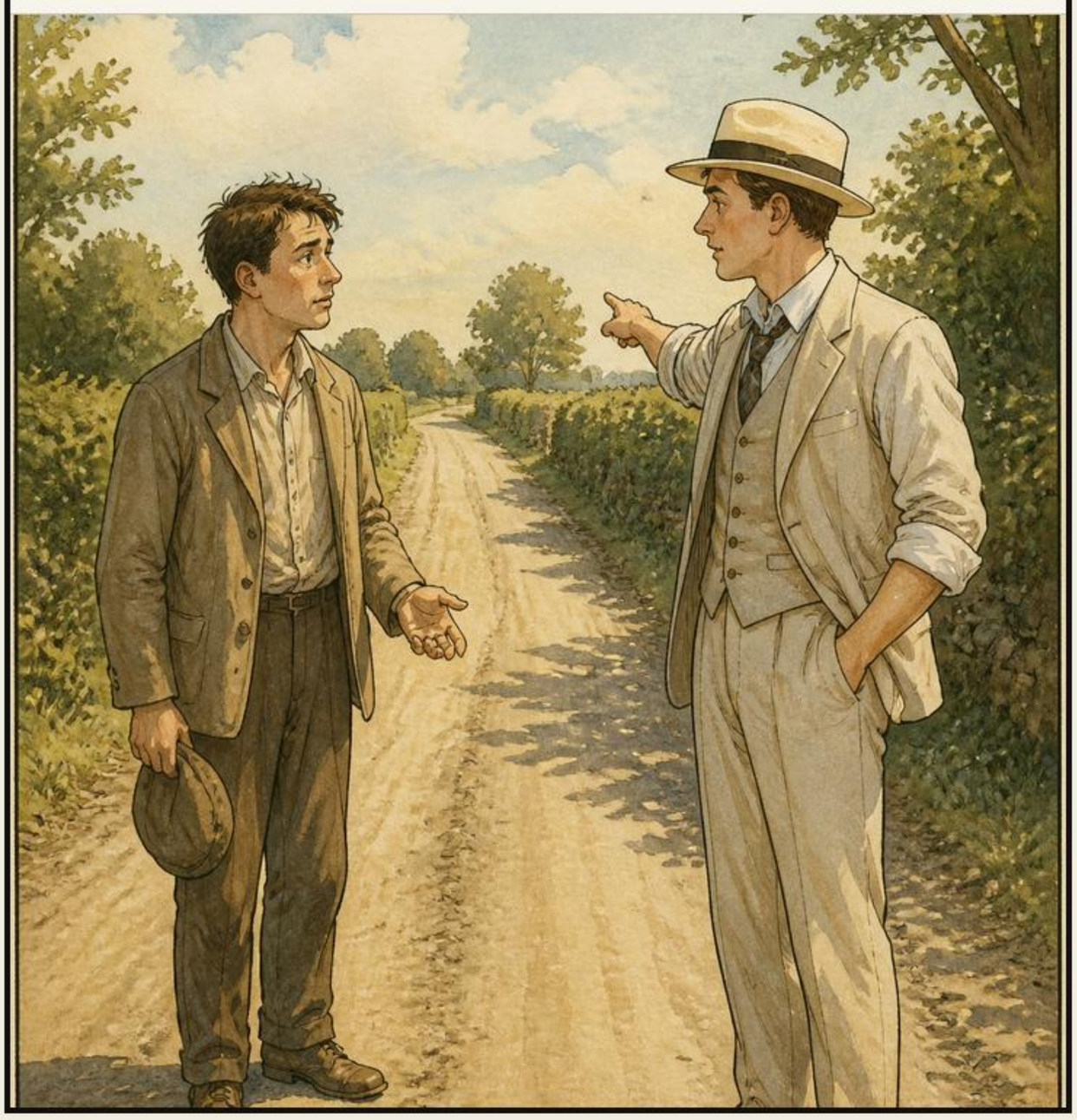
My family had been prominent, well-to-do people in this Middle Western city for three generations. I graduated from New Haven in 1915, then took part in that delayed Teutonic migration called the Great War — and I enjoyed the counter-raid so thoroughly that I came back restless.



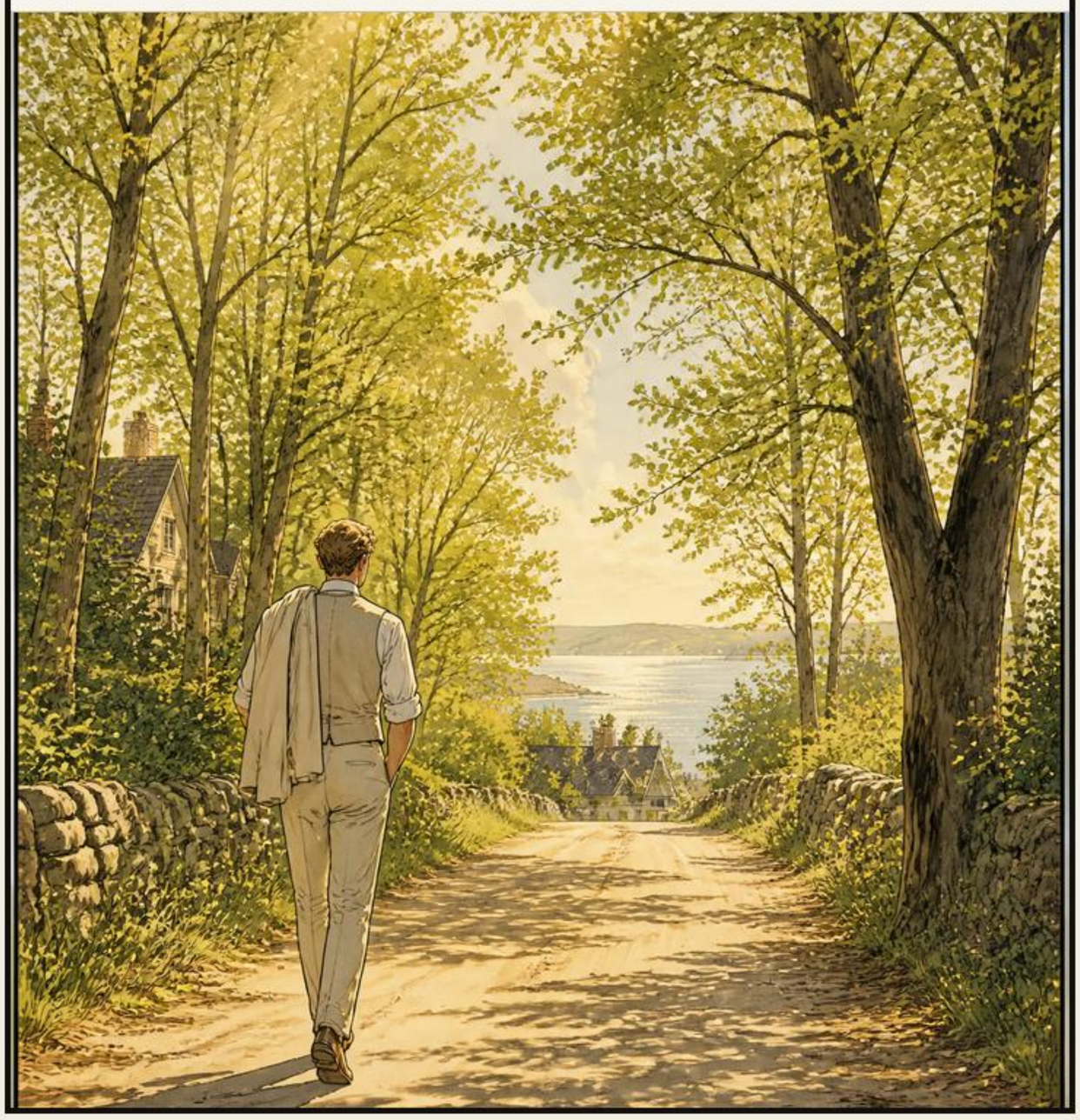
He found the house—a weather-beaten cardboard bungalow at eighty a month. At the last minute the firm ordered him to Washington, and I went out to the country alone. I had a dog, an old Dodge, and a Finnish woman who muttered Finnish wisdom over the electric stove.



It was lonely for a day or so—until one morning some man, more recently arrived than I, stopped me on the road and asked how to get to West Egg village. I told him.



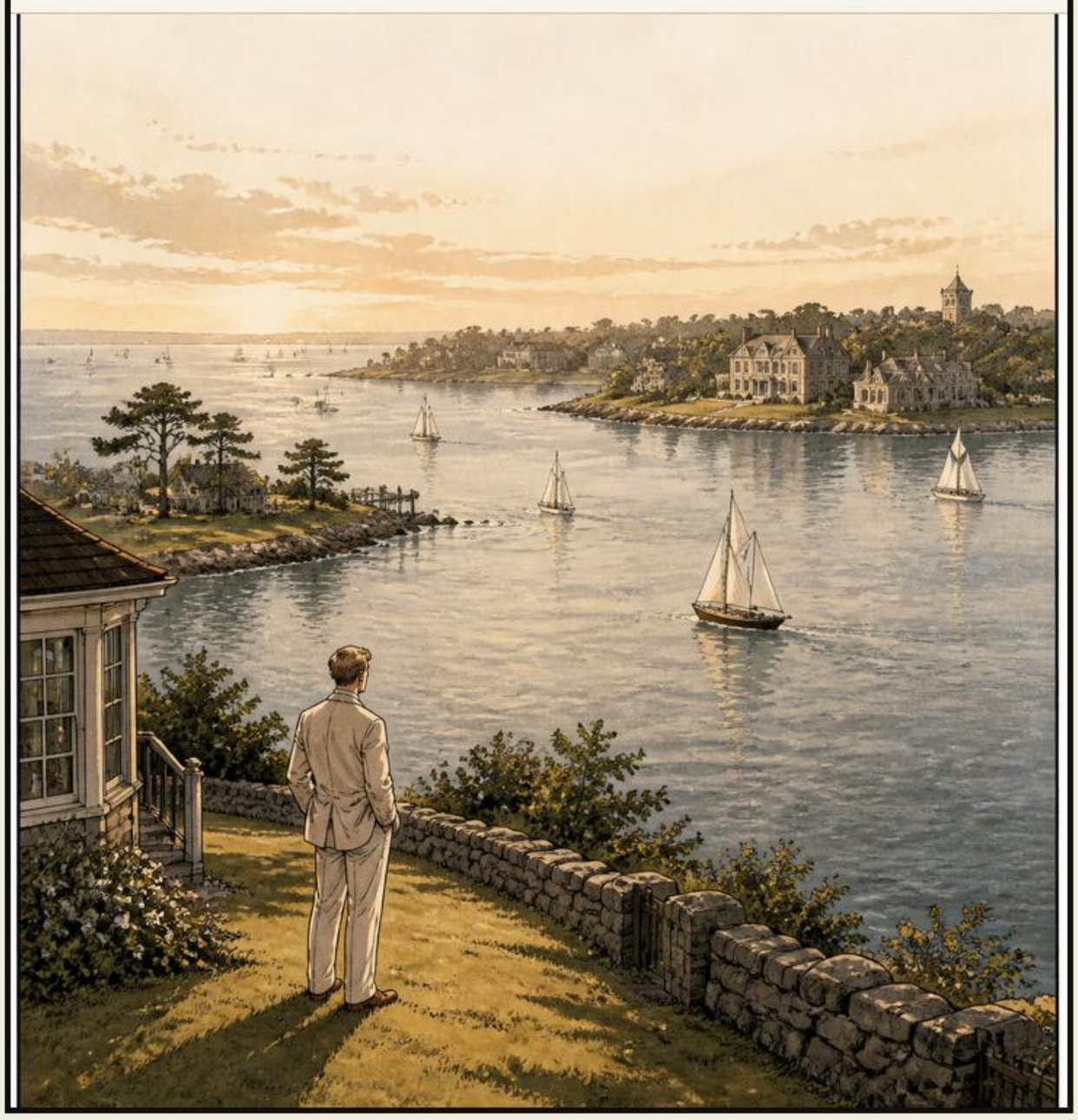
And as I walked on, I was lonely no longer. I was a guide, a pathfinder, an original settler—he had casually conferred on me the freedom of the neighbourhood.



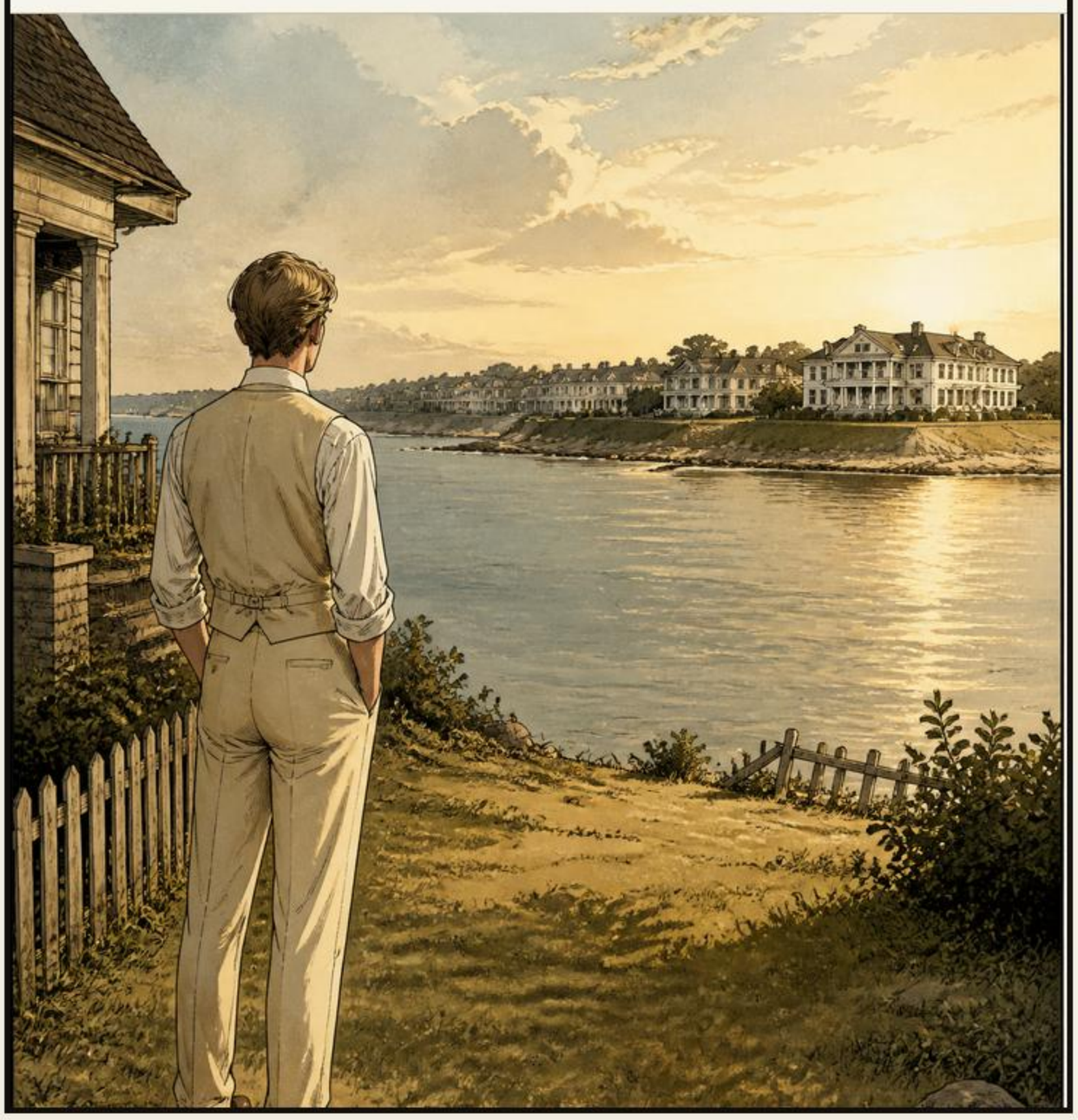
There was so much to read, and so much fine health to pull down out of the air. I bought a dozen volumes on banking and credit, standing on my shelf in red and gold like new money from the mint—promising the shining secrets only Midas and Morgan and Maecenas knew. I was going to be that most limited of specialists, the well-rounded man.



On that slender riotous island east of New York, twenty miles from the city, a pair of enormous eggs jut into the great wet barnyard of Long Island Sound.



I lived at West Egg—the less fashionable of the two, though that tag scarcely expresses the bizarre and not a little sinister contrast between them.



On my right stood a colossal affair—a factual imitation of some Hôtel de Ville in Normandy, a tower under a thin beard of raw ivy, a marble pool, forty acres of lawn. It was Gatsby's mansion—or rather, since I'd never met him, a mansion inhabited by a gentleman of that name.





My own house was an eyesore, but a small one, and overlooked—so I had a view of the water, a partial view of my neighbour's lawn, and the consoling proximity of millionaires—all for eighty dollars a month.